Dejan Zafirev

PhD Student and Research Assistant in Financial Economics
University of Liechtenstein

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Positions

since 07/2025 — **Research Assistant (50%)**, Department of Business Economics, University of Liechtenstein
Empirical research in financial economics (asset pricing, derivatives, political uncertainty); support for research projects, seminars, and teaching.

11/2024–05/2025 — **Product Control Intern**, HypoVereinsbank (UniCredit), Munich
Daily P&L decomposition for Equity and FICC desks; VBA automation of Excel reporting workflows.

Education

since 2025 — **PhD in Business Economics (Financial Economics)**, University of Liechtenstein
Cumulative thesis based on research papers in financial economics.

2022–2024 — **MSc in Economics (Quantitative Finance)**, University of Freiburg
Thesis: *Option Pricing Models Beyond the Black–Scholes Framework* (Heston, Variance Gamma, and SABR models calibrated to S&P 500 implied volatilities). Grade average 1.9 (German scale).

2018–2022 — **BSc in Economics (Management and Finance)**, University of Ss. Cyril and Methodius, North Macedonia
Thesis: *Impact of Digitalization on Economic Growth* (panel data analysis). Grade average 9.2 (Macedonian scale).

Research interests

Empirical asset pricing; political uncertainty, populism, and financial markets; derivatives, option pricing, and volatility modelling; financial econometrics and reproducible empirical methods.

Working papers

What Drives the Price of Populism? Liberal Commitments and Market Perceptions of Political Risk
Work in progress. Event study around elections combining text-based populism and liberalism measures with option-implied risk measures.

Publications

Populism, Political Uncertainty, and Option Markets
D. Zafirev, S. Stöckl. Book chapter, accepted for the *Handbook on Economic Populism* (eds. Rode, Hartwell, Stöckl), Edward Elgar.

Presentations

07/2026 — APF International Conference of Macroeconomics and Finance, Athens University of Economics and Business, Athens
"What Drives the Price of Populism? Liberal Commitments and Market Perceptions of Political Risk."

Certificates

04/2025 — Applied Data Science Lab, WorldQuant University
Project-based training in Python, SQL, data visualization, and machine learning.

Skills

Programming — Python (Pandas, NumPy, SciPy, Matplotlib), R, SQL, VBA, LaTeX

Tools — Excel, Power BI, EViews, Jupyter, Git

Languages — Macedonian (native), English (C1), Croatian (B1), German (B1)